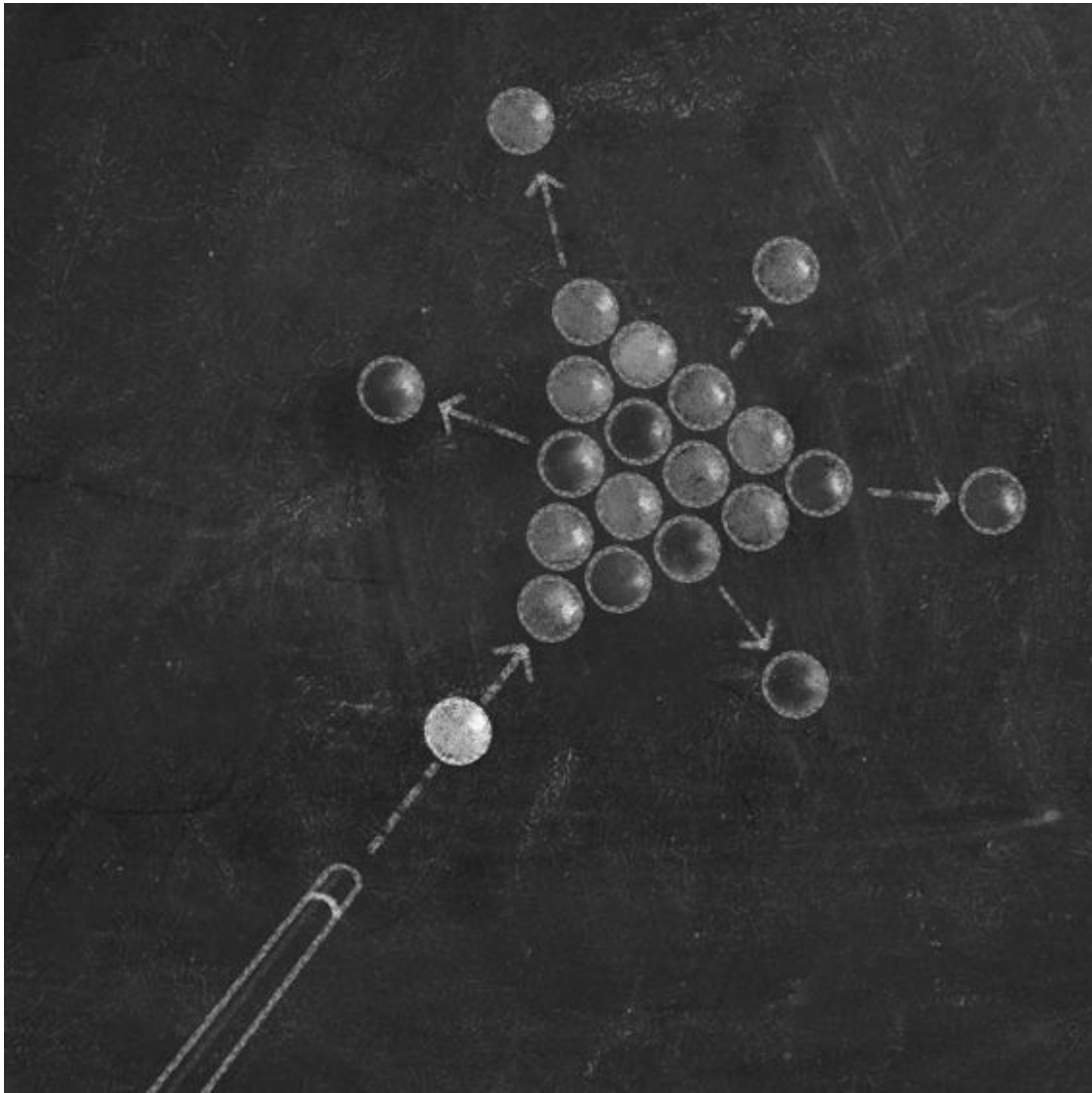


Hume and causality



Probably the most important of the empiricists was David Hume. He agreed with Locke's argument that we acquire knowledge only through experience, but realized that consistent application of this principle means we cannot know anything with certainty. The major drawback of empirical knowledge, he pointed out, is that just because we see something happen after something else doesn't prove there is a cause-and-effect relationship. But this notion that one thing causes another is fundamental to any attempt to understand the world; causal relationships help us to see a structure to the universe rather than just a collection of separate, unrelated events. Hume

argued that apparent causal relationships are simply ‘constant conjunctions’ of events. We assume that a billiard ball will move when struck by another, because in our experience this has always happened. But a clock set slightly slow will consistently chime a few minutes after one that is correct, yet we do not infer a causal relationship. Intuitively, we know the cases are different, but what are our grounds for thinking that?